

## Inside S. Korea’s six hours of chaos

Martial law declaration may have been in works for months, probes show

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE AND SO JIN JUNG

SEOUL — It seemed far-fetched this summer when some opposition lawmakers here began warning that South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol might declare martial law.

Some said it was just a gut feeling. Others said they saw ominous signs, like the way Yoon abruptly installed an old high school friend as his defense minister.

But the concerns proved warranted. Yoon imposed martial law in the middle of the night on Dec. 3, plunging South Korea into its worst political crisis in decades — with the defense minister playing a critical role.

Much is still unknown about exactly what prompted Yoon, a conservative who was new to politics, to declare martial law — the first such decree in South Korea in more than four decades. Lawmakers swiftly voted to reject it, and Yoon rescinded his order less than six hours after issuing it.

Yoon was impeached 11 days after that disastrous gambit. The Constitutional Court must decide whether to remove Yoon from office. He is also under criminal investigation seeking to determine whether his actions amounted to insurrection.

Prime Minister Han Duck-soo, who took over from Yoon as interim president, was himself impeached Friday amid criticism from the opposition that he was stalling judicial appointments at the Constitutional Court that are needed to continue Yoon’s impeachment process. Choi Sang-mok, South Korea’s deputy prime minister and finance minister, will assume the country’s acting presidency.

In the days since the extraordinary night of Dec. 3, the National Assembly has convened hearings

SEE SOUTH KOREA ON A5



MICHAEL S. WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

Sabina Cristobal reunites with her grandson, Sebastián Villaorduña, on the field at Fort Jackson in Columbia, South Carolina, on Nov. 27 as her husband, Primitivo Melgarejo, left, watches. They had traveled from Peru to see him graduate from basic training.

## He’s becoming an American soldier. First he must become a U.S. citizen.

Sebastián is willing to die for his new country. In return, he hopes for ‘a new purpose.’

BY MISSY RYAN AND GREG JAFFE

FORT JACKSON, S.C. — Sebastián Villaorduña hadn’t even sworn his oath of citizenship but had already committed to fighting, and potentially dying, for America.

The 23-year-old had arrived in the United States from Peru only 18 months earlier, reuniting with his undocumented mother, whom he hadn’t seen in more than a decade.

On a drizzly morning in late November, he stood in formation with 121 soon-to-be soldiers hailing from five continents and more than a dozen countries. Soon they would graduate from Army basic training. First, though, they would become Americans.

All were clad in camouflage, their right hands raised, their eyes fixed on a laptop where a representative of the Citizenship and Immigration Services was leading them via Zoom through the naturalization oath of allegiance. Together, they accounted for about 10 percent of Sebastián’s basic training class.

A short distance away, a crowd of family members leaned over a chain-link fence, cellphones in hand, trying to catch a first glimpse of their loved ones who had left home 10 weeks earlier. The new citizens finished their oath. Lt. Col. Paul Hargrove, the basic training battalion commander, strode to the front of the formation.

“When I look at you, I see America,” he said, his voice booming. “I see the American story.”

Sebastián scanned the crowd on the other side of the fence, looking for the relatives who had come to see him graduate, especially his mother, Daysi Wong.

She had left him with his grandparents in Peru when he was still in grade school, then made her way on foot from Mexico across the U.S. border. During their years apart, she had scraped together a new life in New Jersey, scrubbing floors and sending money home each month for Sebastián’s education. She had married a U.S. citizen and was

SEE SOLDIER ON A6

## Welcome to the loneliest Metro station

Loudoun Gateway was envisioned as a thriving mixed-use stop. Instead, it’s anything but.

BY JOE HEIM

It’s rush hour on a cold December afternoon, and the platform at the Loudoun Gateway Metro station is empty.

The only sounds are the steady hum of traffic zooming along the adjacent Dulles Greenway and an occasional whoosh of whipping wind. An announcement on the public address system presumably provides an important Metro update. It’s too garbled to tell.

Just before 6 p.m., a train arrives heading west to Ashburn and pulls to a stop. There are riders seated inside, but when the Metro doors slide open, no one steps out. And there’s no one waiting to step on.

The least-used stop on Metro is experiencing yet another least-used moment.

Doors closing.

About 400,000 people ride Metro trains daily, making it the second-busiest subway system in the country behind New York City’s. Most of the system’s 98 stations bustle with energy during

SEE METRO ON A8



MICHAEL S. WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

A lone passenger waits for a train at the Loudoun Gateway Metro station in Sterling, Virginia, on Dec. 5. Loudoun Gateway is Metro’s least-used stop, with an average of 317 people entering it each day.

## Conflict over work visas tests Trump’s coalition

BY PRANSHU VERMA AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

Far-right activists clashed online with billionaire Elon Musk and other supporters of President-elect Donald Trump over the need for a skilled-worker immigration program that has long been a lifeblood for Silicon Valley — signifying a potential rift between Trump’s core nationalist base and technology executives who have come to support him.

The fight that spilled into public view over the holiday week could preview a wedge within Trump’s coalition over how to execute immigration policy, an issue that animated Trump’s White House campaign.

The controversy spread across X after far-right activist Laura Loomer on Monday criticized Trump’s choice to name Sriram Krishnan, a technology entrepreneur and investor who was born in India, as his senior policy adviser on artificial intelligence. She pointed to Krishnan’s previous support for removing some caps on green cards and easing the

ability of skilled foreign workers to come to the United States. The policy is “in direct opposition” to Trump’s agenda, Loomer wrote.

The critique sparked a broader debate about immigration in the tech industry, which relies heavily on a visa program that allows foreigners with technical skills to work in the United States for up to six years under H-1B nonimmigrant status.

It ran headlong into tension with some of Trump’s closest advisers, notably Tesla and SpaceX CEO Musk; David Sacks, who will be the president-elect’s AI and crypto czar; and Vivek Ramaswamy, who will co-lead a commission to cut government spending. Ramaswamy argued American culture doesn’t produce enough skilled workers to fuel cutting-edge companies. “Normalcy” doesn’t cut it in a hyper-competitive global market for technical talent,” he wrote on X. “And if we pretend like it does, we’ll have our asses handed to us by China.”

The online fight sparked a slew of racist posts from Loomer and

SEE VISA ON A2

### IN THE NEWS

**Surge among the unhoused** Homelessness spiked 18 percent to reach the highest level on record, according to a Department of Housing and Urban Development report. A3

**‘Machinery of death’** Mass graves discovered in Syria hint at the extent of Bashar al-Assad’s slaughter of his own people. A4

**THE NATION** NASA’s Parker Solar Probe has survived after traveling within 3.8 million miles of the sun. A3  
**A Senate report** faulted the CIA’s response to the mystery ailment “Havana syndrome.” A3

**THE WORLD** China unveiled futuristic fighter jets that could mark a breakthrough in modernization. A5  
**Israel** is signaling a wider military campaign against Houthis militants in Yemen. A7

**The plane** that crashed in Kazakhstan this week appears to have been brought down by Russia, the U.S. said. A8

**THE ECONOMY** Shoppers chased discounts to drive a stronger-than-expected holiday season for retailers. A9

**THE REGION** A man in Northeast died in a hit-and-run while standing on the sidewalk as the driver fled the scene by foot. B1  
**As Richmond’s** mayor, Levar Stoney, leaves office, the city has been changed by protests over statues of Civil War figures. B1

**STYLE** This year, “celebrity style” finally died, and a new era of style began to take its place. C1

**SPORTS** Alex Ovechkin, who broke his leg in November, could be back tonight to resume his chase of Wayne Gretzky’s all-time NHL goals mark. D1

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